

Don Carlos — Green Sauce packaging & identity

A label, a campaign, and the system underneath both — built to read as an established heritage brand from the first sketch.

Brief

Don Carlos carries three generations of family legacy — a grandmother's restaurant, a father's nickname — bottled today as a single product, Green Sauce. The identity had to feel dignified and earned, like a brand that had been around for decades, not a launch. Never rustic-farmers-market, never AI-generic.

Approach

Rather than jump straight to the label, we built the full system first — type, color, components — before any real deliverable existed. Every piece that followed, from the bottle to the ad campaign to the wordmark itself, draws from that one foundation. Nothing was designed as a one-off.

Key decisions

A wordmark-only identity

We rejected the instinct to add a chili icon or illustrative decoration, even when early ad compositions felt like they needed something more to signal "hot sauce" to someone unfamiliar with the brand. The custom hand-lettered wordmark had to carry full weight on its own — reaching for decoration would have been a shortcut, and the single most common visual cliché in the category besides.

The tagline pivot

The first pass landed on "three generations. one recipe." — true, but generic enough to belong to any heritage food brand. We replaced it with "goes with everything," a line rooted in what people actually say about the sauce firsthand. It's a small edit that puts the brand's own content principle into practice: specificity over cliché.

A flexible three-background system

Rather than lock the brand to one fixed palette, we built it to hold up across near-black, deep green, and cream. Rotating grounds across the label variants and campaign pieces wasn't about variety for its own sake — it was a stress test, proving the system's discipline (one accent color, one type pairing, held constant) rather than its rigidity.

The system

The finished foundation is the throughline connecting every deliverable below: three approved backgrounds, one accent green used only to signal product, Fraunces paired against Work Sans for deliberate display/body contrast, a sharp-to-slightly-rounded corner scale, and a dot-based heat-level component built once and reused everywhere spice needed signaling.



Handoff

The finished label (three background variants), the five-piece ad campaign, a standalone wordmark showcase, and a brand foundations spread are ready for the build on doncarlosdesign.com.

Green Sauce label — 3 background variants

Ad campaign — 5 pieces

Wordmark showcase

Brand foundations spread
